Parshas Chukas

When We Do Not Understand

Parah Adumah · Aharon · Shalom · Yiftach

I. What Is a Chok?

What is a chok to begin with?

Depending on who you are learning from, there are different ways of classifying mitzvos and halachos. One common framework, brought down especially within mysticism, splits them into chukim, mishpatim, and eidus. Eidus is the easiest to define. Shabbos is an eidus, a testimony, that Hashem created the heavens and the earth. Pesach is an eidus to Yetziyas Mitzrayim. Chanukah and Purim each testify to their own stories. Mishpatim make sense to us on their own terms. Do not murder. Do not steal. Even without Torah, a person can understand why a society needs these laws to function. Tort law, damages, litigation, these all sit comfortably inside human logic.

Then there are chukim. A chok sits outside the normal reach of human reasoning. People like to offer modern justifications. Maybe pig is forbidden because of trichinosis. Maybe shellfish are forbidden because they are bottom feeders. Maybe certain birds carry some negative quality in their meat. There may be layers of meaning there, and they are worth learning. But that is not the foundation. The foundation is simpler and deeper than any of that: Hashem said so. This is Hashem's world, Hashem's reality, and this is what Hashem asks of me.

II. Parah Adumah: Death and the Return to Life

The parsha opens with exactly this kind of chok, the Parah Adumah. A red heifer is burned, its ashes mixed with water and hyssop and other specific items, and through this process someone who is tamei meis, carrying the strongest level of tumah that exists, becomes pure again. It is genuinely strange. It sits beyond human intellect entirely.

There is a perspective, rooted in the parsha itself, that connects the color of the heifer back to the Eigel HaZahav, the golden calf. Red carries a connection to gold, or to a reddish shade of gold. The heifer is burned, turned to ash, as a kind of reversal: instead of building up something that was bad, as the people did when they built the calf, we burn it down. The tumah of avodah zarah stands opposite to life. Tumah from contact with death pulls

a person toward that same direction. But the idea behind the Parah Adumah is that we are still alive. We want to purify ourselves, to separate from the pull of death, and choose life.

And specifically, the tumah that the Parah Adumah comes to address is tumas meis, the impurity that comes from contact with death itself:

זֹאת חֻקַּת הַתּוֹרָה... וְהַנֹּגֵעַ בְּמֵת בְּנֶפֶשׁ הָאָדָם וְטָמֵא שִׁבְעַת יָמִים

"This is the chukas haTorah... and one who touches the dead body of a person shall be impure for seven days."

— Bamidbar 19:2,11

The chok itself may not be explainable in ordinary terms, but the orientation it points toward, away from death and toward life, is something we can feel even without fully understanding the mechanism. And it is specifically this, the Torah giving us a path to purify from contact with death, that becomes a fitting introduction to what comes next in the parsha: two of our own leaders, Miriam and then Aharon, leaving this world.

III. Two Deaths in One Parsha

Miriam passes away, and shortly after, Aharon passes away as well.

When Miriam is niftar, there is a noticeable shift in the lashon of the pesukim. We will not go deeply into the textual specifics here, but immediately afterward the well that had sustained Klal Yisrael in her merit disappears. The people need water. What follows is the well-known story where Moshe hits the rock rather than speaking to it, and a din comes down as a result: Moshe and Aharon will not enter Eretz Yisrael. Very shortly after that, Aharon himself is niftar.

The way Aharon's passing is described carries a quality of acceptance, of calm, of peace. He goes up the mountain. He accepts what is coming to him without resistance. He passes in a way that is beautiful, loving, and dignified. The people, at first, are in a kind of denial, and Hashem shows them an image of Aharon being lifted so they can understand what has happened. From there, they mourn for thirty days, crying the loss of a beloved leader, someone who was ohev shalom and rodef shalom, a lover and pursuer of peace.

IV. What Disappeared When Aharon Did

Moshe Rabbeinu was the greatest leader Klal Yisrael ever had, the embodiment of anivus and bitul, humility and selflessness. But Aharon carried something distinct. Aharon would bend reality, even bend truth in small ways, in order to create peace between people. That was his particular gift, his avodah.

And when Aharon leaves the world, something specific happens. We are taught that the Ananei HaKavod, the Clouds of Glory that had been protecting Klal Yisrael from their enemies throughout the desert, stopped. The shalom that Aharon had established, that atmosphere of peace that had surrounded the camp, went with him. And almost immediately afterward in this very parsha, we read about threats arising. Og tries to wage war. The people request passage through the land of Ammon and are refused. The mefarshim describe Og attempting to lift an entire mountain and drop it onto Klal Yisrael, only for it to land on his own head and trap him there, giving Moshe Rabbeinu the opening to strike him in the ankle with an axe and kill him.

But underneath the details of these specific battles, the deeper question remains: who is a leader? How does a leader embody himself? How do the people respond when that leader is gone?

V. Brother Against Brother, and What It Wasn't

We cannot say that Klal Yisrael was always loving and always at peace while Aharon was alive. They complained constantly, even later in this very parsha, about the mann, tired of it, ungrateful for it. But there is an important distinction here. The friction during Aharon's lifetime was not predominantly brother against brother. There were fights rooted in gaivah, disputes over who deserved a certain title or role, but it was not a wholesale breakdown of neighbor against neighbor.

Of course, we have to set aside a few specific episodes. Korach's rebellion came from gaivah, from a desire to fulfill ratzon Hashem but in a direction that missed the mark entirely. And there were also the rabble rousers, the naysayers, those whose behavior the mefarshim connect to the influence of the Erev Rav, the mixed multitude that had joined Klal Yisrael in Mitzrayim without fully internalizing where they were going. Once we set those specific episodes aside as their own category, what remains is mostly an absence: moments where love, beauty, and mutual understanding simply were not active forces in the world. That absence itself creates a shift. It can be a painful shift, one where people become blind to what they actually had, until they start tripping over themselves without realizing why.

VI. A Personal Note

This is also the week of Gimmel Tammuz, the third of Tammuz, which carries its own resonance with exactly this theme. It marks the yahrzeit of the Lubavitcher Rebbe, zt"l, a leader whose passing was felt as a visible, public change of leadership in our generation, the kind of moment where the world genuinely shifts because of who is no longer in front of us. And this week, someone from my own kehillah was niftar after a multi-year battle and a great deal of pain and suffering. At the very least, we can say that he is no longer in that pain.

The loss and change of leadership that happens in the world, on any scale, communal or personal, is not easy. But when the right leadership is in place, even overwhelming troubles can be managed. We can say: I have so much pain, but here is my leader. The right leader, the good leader. I am trying very hard not to turn this into politics, and I will not pretend I am happy with the global state of affairs right now. But with the right leader in front of us, our enemies do not get to take our shalom from us. We can set that example ourselves, maintain that perspective, and remain at peace even while everything around us feels unstable.

VII. Yiftach: Pushed Aside, Then Needed

This theme carries directly into the Haftarah, the story of Yiftach HaGiladi. Tanach tells us plainly that Yiftach was the son of a woman described as a zonah. His brothers rejected him because of this, sent him away, refused to let him inherit alongside them. He was pushed to the margins.

And then Gilead came under attack. The same people who had pushed him out lost their bearings entirely. They did not know how to respond to the threat, and in their confusion, the elders came to Yiftach and asked him to lead them. There is a real lesson of bitul here. The person considered smaller, pushed aside, can become the very leader the people need most. And Yiftach's response is worth noting carefully. He does not say, thank you so much for finally seeing the light, of course I will lead you now. Instead, his orientation is: I will step in, and let us see how Hashem responds. If Hashem grants success, we will have success and peace again. If not, then not. The outcome belongs to Hashem, not to his own vindication.

That posture echoes Aharon directly. Yiftach first pursues peace and diplomacy, sending a message to the king of Ammon, laying out the historical facts of how the land came to

Klal Yisrael, that it was not stolen from Ammon but taken from Sichon king of the Emori in a just war. This mirrors exactly what Klal Yisrael does earlier in the parsha itself, when they request permission to pass through the land:

נֵלְכָה נָּא בְאַרְצֶךָ לֹא נִטֶּה בְּשָׂדֶה וּבְכֶרֶם וְלֹא נִשְׁתֶּה מֵי בְאֵר בְּדֶרֶךְ הַמֶּלֶךְ נֵלֵךְ

"Please let us pass through your land. We will not turn aside into any field or vineyard, nor will we drink water from any well. We will go by the king's highway."

— Bamidbar 20:17

When refused, they simply go around. They do not pick the fight. The other side does.

VIII. Battles We Never Even Saw

There is another remarkable piece tied into all of this, the story of Nachalei Arnon, where the Amorites set an ambush for Klal Yisrael in the mountains and valleys. Klal Yisrael did not even know the danger existed. Only afterward do they hear about it, see the evidence in the bloody waters, and understand what they had been protected from. There is a shir in this week's parsha that commemorates exactly that moment.

That is a tremendous yesod to sit with. We often assume we know the full story of what we have faced and survived. But there are dangers removed before we ever reach them, threats that fall away before we know they existed. Sometimes the song of gratitude only comes after the danger has already passed, once we finally see what we never saw in the moment.

We move forward in a way that is smooth but not passive. We do not let enemies simply walk over us. We move forward understanding that Hashem has our back, that proper leadership matters, and that we look to Hashem first for guidance and direction in every situation.

IX. Looking Up

The parsha also gives us the story of the copper snake on the pole. The people complain again, this time about the mann, and deaths come as a consequence. Hashem tells Moshe:

עֲשֵׂה לְךָ שָׂרָף וְשִׂים אֹתוֹ עַל נֵס וְהָיָה כָּל הַנָּשׁוּךְ וְרָאָה אֹתוֹ וָחָי

"Make for yourself a fiery serpent and place it on a pole, and it shall be that anyone who is bitten, when he looks at it, he will live."

— Bamidbar 21:8

Chazal teach that it was never the snake itself that healed. It was the act of looking upward, of turning the heart back toward Hashem, that brought the healing.

That is, in many ways, the whole message of this parsha. We do the right thing, and we look to Hashem first. Usually, Hashem takes care of our enemies before we even need to go to war. And when we do need to fight, we fight in a kosher and yashar way. We do not always understand the chok. We do not always understand why Moshe could not enter Eretz Yisrael, why Aharon's passing removed the Ananei HaKavod, why some dangers are hidden from us until after they have already passed. But the avodah of Chukas is not to understand everything. It is to remain loyal, to remain connected, and to keep walking forward, looking up, even when the path itself is something we cannot fully explain.

חזק ואחזק

Good Shabbos

Reflection Questions

> - *Where in my life am I asking for an explanation before I am willing to act, when what is actually being asked of me is a chok, a willingness to trust without full understanding?*
> - *Whose presence in my life functions the way Aharon's did, creating an atmosphere of shalom that I may not fully notice until it is gone? Have I told them what that has meant?*
> - *Where in my own circles, family, community, or otherwise, has friction quietly shifted from disagreement into something closer to brother against brother? What would it take to pull it back?*
> - *Is there someone in my life who has been pushed aside, like Yiftach, who may actually be exactly who is needed right now if given the chance?*
> - *Where have I tried the path of peace first, requesting and waiting and going around, before assuming confrontation was necessary?*
> - *What battles have likely been fought for me that I never even saw? How does that change the way I move through the world today?*